Oldest Museum – The museum of Ennigaldi-Nanna in Mesopotamia was established in 530 BC (BCE). The Princess Ennigaldi was the daughter of the neo-Babylonian king Nabonidus. The Capitoline Museum in Italy is perhaps the oldest surviving museum (1471 AD (CE)) at present. Ashmolean Museum at Oxford University is the oldest university museum in the world. It was established in 1677 AD (CE).

Herbert Spencer's (1820–1903 AD (CE)) biological evolution, and Charles Darwin's (1809–1882 AD (CE)) theory on concepts of **natural selection and survival of the fittest** contributed to the scientific understanding of human origins. Charles Darwin published the books *On the Origin of Species* in 1859 and *The Descent of Man in 1871.*

Natural selection – The process by which organisms that are better adapted to their environment would survive and produce more offspring.

Survival of the fittest means "survival of the form that will leave the most copies of itself in successive generations."

Fossil – Prehistoric animal or plant that turns into stone over a period of time (millions of years) because of chemical and physical processes. Animal bones are preserved due to mineralization. Palaeontology is the study of fossils.

Stone Age – the period when stone was mainly used for making implements.

Bronze Age – the period when bronze metallurgy (extraction of metal from ores) developed.

Iron Age – the period when iron was smelted to produce implements.

Since the 19th century, scholars have used advanced scientific techniques. They undertook systematic studies to contribute to the current state of knowledge on prehistory, human origins and the early civilisations. Now the theory of human evolution is widely accepted.

1.3 Prehistory: From Australopithecus through Homo erectus to Homo sapiens

Who are we? What is the name of our species?

We are *Homo sapiens*

Human Evolution and Migration

The chimpanzee, gorillas and orangutans, along with humans, are collectively called the Great Apes. Among them, the chimpanzee is genetically the closest to humans.

The ancestors to humans were called Hominins, and their origins have been traced in Africa. They evolved from those origins and then began to move to other parts of the world in due course of time. The *Hominins* emerged around 7 to 5 million years ago. Skeletons of *Australopithecus*, one of the early species of this tribe, have been found in Africa.

The Great Rift Valley in Africa has many sites that have evidence for the prehistoric period.



The DNA of a chimpanzee is 98% identical to that of a human being.

The Great Rift Valley is a valley-like formation that runs for about 6,400 km from the northern part of Syria to Central Mozambique in East Africa. This geographical feature is visible even from the space, and many prehistoric sites are found in eastern Africa.

Human ancestors are divided into various species according to their physical features.

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